executioner and the inquisitors. If the accused refused to confess, this was taken as evidence of their demonic obstinacy, and they were then tortured in horrendous ways, their fingers broken, their flesh cut with hot pincers, their bodies stretched to the breaking point or submerged in boiling water. Sooner or later they could stand it no longer and confessed – and were duly executed.[80]

To take one example, in 1600 authorities in Munich arrested on suspicion of witchcraft the Pappenheimer family – father Paulus, mother Anna, two grown sons and a ten-year-old boy, Hansel. The inquisitors began by torturing little Hansel. The protocol of the interrogation, which can still be read in the Munich archives, has a note from one of the interrogators regarding the ten-year-old boy: 'May be tortured to the limit so that he incriminates his mother.'[81] After being tortured in unspeakable ways, the Pappenheimers confessed to numerous crimes, including killing 265 people by sorcery and causing fourteen destructive storms. They were all condemned to death.

The bodies of each of the four adult family members were torn with red-hot pincers, the men's limbs were broken on the wheel, the father was impaled on a stake, the mother's breasts were cut off, and all were then burned alive. The ten-year-old Hansel was forced to watch all this. Four months later, he too was executed.[82] The witch-hunters were extremely thorough in their search for the Devil and his accomplices. But if the witch-hunters really wanted to find diabolical evil, they just had to look in the mirror.

THE SPANISH INQUISITION TO THE RESCUE

Witch hunts seldom ended by killing just one person or one family. Since the underlying model postulated a global conspiracy, people accused of witchcraft were tortured to name accomplices. This was then used as evidence to imprison, torture and execute others. If any officials, scholars or churchmen voiced objections to these absurd methods, this could be seen as proof that they too must be witches – which led to their own arrest and torture.

For example, in 1453 – when belief in the satanic conspiracy was just beginning to take hold – a French doctor of theology called Guillaume